too big a step up and too soon. There were probably a few thousand United supporters headed back from the game who'd been wondering the same thing. But by the time we'd all got home and were hearing the experts write us off, I'm sure I wasn't the only one getting riled by the criticism. It had just been one game, after all. *What if we go out and prove the lot of you wrong?*

The next game was at home to West Ham and, for all that he'd criticized me after the Villa match, the manager named me in the team. Plenty of things rushed through my head, especially the realization that starting the game meant I would be lining up opposite Julian Dicks. I don't know why but I found myself remembering a boy I'd been friendly with at Chingford High, Danny Fisher, who was a mad, mad West Ham fan. I'd always looked out for their results, too, even though I was a Manchester United supporter, and the two of us talked and argued about soccer all the time. What would Danny be thinking now when he saw me lining up against West Ham and against Julian Dicks? I knew what I was thinking: this bloke's a really hard player.

In my early United career, I think there were doubts about whether I'd ever be physically tough enough to cope with first-team soccer. As an eight-year-old playing Sunday League soccer, I believed I was good enough then to have been playing for United. I know other people were concerned that, even at seventeen and eighteen, I hadn't really grown: It was talked about at the club and I also remember talking about it with Dad. I worked with weights to make me stronger but the spurt that took me up to over 70 inches didn't happen until much later. But, whatever anyone else said, I wasn't worried about my size. I was determined it wouldn't hold me back, anyway. I'd always played soccer against people who were bigger and stronger than me. Julian Dicks, though? The manager had a word with me in the dressing room before kick off:

'When you get your chance, run at him or get your cross in. But watch yourself. If he can whack you, he will.'

And he did early on, down by the corner flag. But Dicks could play, too, and I knew I needed to keep going because, if he got the better of me, he was the best passer of the ball in West Ham's team. The United fans were fantastic that night. They might have been nervous about the stars who'd left in the summer. But I think they loved watching homegrown talent doing well for the club. Gary and Phil Neville, Paul Scholes and Nicky Butt were all Manchester boys, which gave the fans an extra sense of pride. I still wonder now whether the Old Trafford crowd had the same feeling towards me, a Londoner rather than a local lad like the others. I'd like to think they did. Against West Ham,